Evaluating Arguments

Name: _____ Section: _____

Determining Purpose, Viewpoint, and Bias

Author's Purpose: "P. I. E."

The reason or goal for writing or speaking

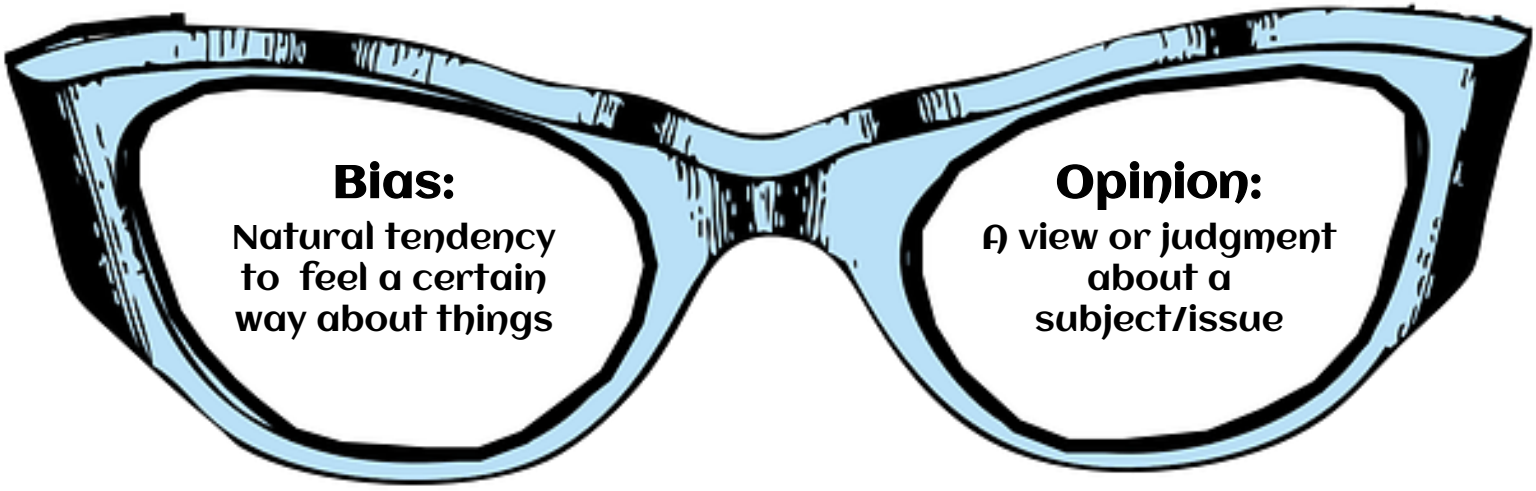
Persuade:
using a variety of appeals to influence another to accept/join your position or point of view on an issue.

Inform:
to objectively give instructions, compare/contrast, share cause and effects, inform about new information

Entertain:
Using narrative, humor, anecdotes, description, or drama, to amuse, delight, and appeal to imagination

Author's Viewpoint

The lens through which the author sees their subject. This lens creates author's perspective, position, opinion, and/or bias within the text



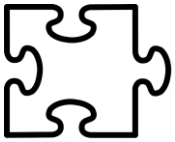
In non-fiction writing, author's purpose and viewpoint are closely related and can be determined by analyzing the use of:

TEXT STRUCTURE **LOADED LANGUAGE** **OPINIONS VS. FACTS**

Evaluating Arguments

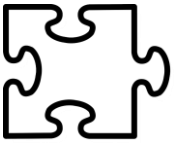
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Determining Purpose, Viewpoint, and Bias



Common Text Structure/Organization

How the text is organized, constructed, or put together for audience



Structure/Organization	Purpose
List or Classification Information to support the main idea is either arranged in a specific order or into specific categories	Typically to inform; however, if listed or categorized by value could be used to persuade
Definition and Example Typically involves one definition context clue, followed by examples to clarify or support the original definition	Used to inform or instruct the audience on new concepts.
Compare and Contrast Information in the passage contains two or more elements that are compared, contrasted, or both compared and contrasted.	Used for both informing and persuading audiences. Can compare for greater understanding or to persuade that one thing is better than another
Cause-Effect Information in the passage explains the relationship between a cause and the resulting effects.	Typically to inform; however, can be used to persuade one to make choices or take actions that would serve as causes toward a desired effect.
Problem-Solution Information in the passage explores a problem and the actual or potential solutions to the problem.	Used for both informing and persuading audiences. If the solution is predetermined, it most likely is informative; if there are multiple possibly solutions could be persuasive.
Counter-Argument/Rebuttal Information in the passage presents debatable issue , first discussing the opposition's argument and then confronting weakness in opponent's position in a rebuttal argument.	Used to argue and persuade the audience to accept the writer's position or viewpoint.
Premise/Support/Conclusion Providing a statement or proposition with supporting evidence followed by the logical conclusion	Mostly used to argue or persuade.
Narrative/Anecdotal Stories or short accounts involving characters, conflict, dialogue, etc	Mostly used to entertain

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Analyzing Structure/Organization Exercise

Use your notes to analyze and identify the structure and purpose of the following examples

List/Classify Definition/Example Compare/Contrast Cause/Effect Problem/Solution Counter-Argument/Rebuttal Premise/Support/Conclusion Narrative/Anecdotal

Structure: _____ Purpose: _____ Because the car was old, the engine overheated, leaving them stranded on the side of the road, resulting in them missing the wedding.

Structure: _____ Purpose: _____ The Iphone's user interface is more intuitive than the android phones, making it a better phone for first time smart phone buyers.

Structure: _____ Purpose: _____ There are several tips I follow to get good sleep: drink no caffeine, no smoking, no watching television in bed, and good exercise.

Structure: _____ Purpose: _____ Sleep bruxism, also know as nocturnal tooth grinding, is the medical term for clenching or grinding teeth during sleep.

Structure: _____ Purpose: _____ A family of three tomatoes were walking downtown one day when the little baby tomato started lagging behind. The big father tomato walks back to the baby tomato, stomps on her, squashing her into a red paste, and says, "Ketchup!"

Structure: _____ Purpose: _____ Proponents of gun control may argue that less guns will lower crime rates; however, what they fail to consider is the constitutional rights of citizens to bear arms to defend themselves from criminal violence

Structure: _____ Purpose: _____ If computer keeps crashing because of being infected by viruses, you can avoid these issues with internet, anti-virus software downloads.

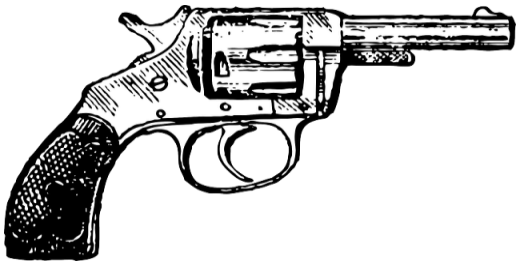
Structure: _____ Purpose: _____ If we don't make efforts to control emissions, then environment will experience radical climate changes. The environment is experiencing strong climate shifts. Therefore we should make efforts to control emissions.

Evaluating Arguments

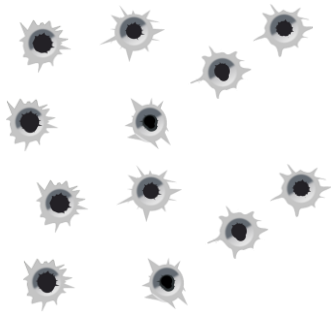
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Determining Purpose, Viewpoint, and Bias

Loaded Language/Words



Powerful words and phrases that reveal the viewpoint or opinion of the author. Loaded words are often used to inspire a certain response (pos. or neg.) within the audience.



Loaded Language/Words Exercise

In the passages below, circle the words that reveal viewpoint or inspire certain emotions

"If books show us the world, teen fiction can be like a hall of fun-house mirrors, constantly reflecting back hideously distorted portrayals of what life is. There are of course exceptions, but a careless young reader—or one who seeks out depravity—will find himself surrounded by images not of joy or beauty but of damage, brutality and losses of the most horrendous kinds."

-Meghan Cox Gurdon (Wall Street Journal, June 2011)-

What is the subject of this text?_____. What is the text's purpose? PERSUADE INFORM ENTERTAIN

What do these words reveal about the viewpoint/opinion/bias of the author concerning this subject? (explain)

_____

_____

_____

And I find it amusing (and somewhat disconcerting) that people make excuses to escape whoever they are supposed to be spending time with so that they can check in with other people who may not even be real-life friends. I like going out to dinner with friends and am bewildered at how many people put their phone on the table and if it vibrates they interrupt whatever is going on to tap a few keys and return to the conversation

-Dr. Larry Rosen (Huffington Post, October 2014)-

What is the subject of this text?_____. What is the text's purpose? PERSUADE INFORM ENTERTAIN

What do these words reveal about the viewpoint/opinion/bias of the author concerning this subject? (explain)

_____

_____

_____

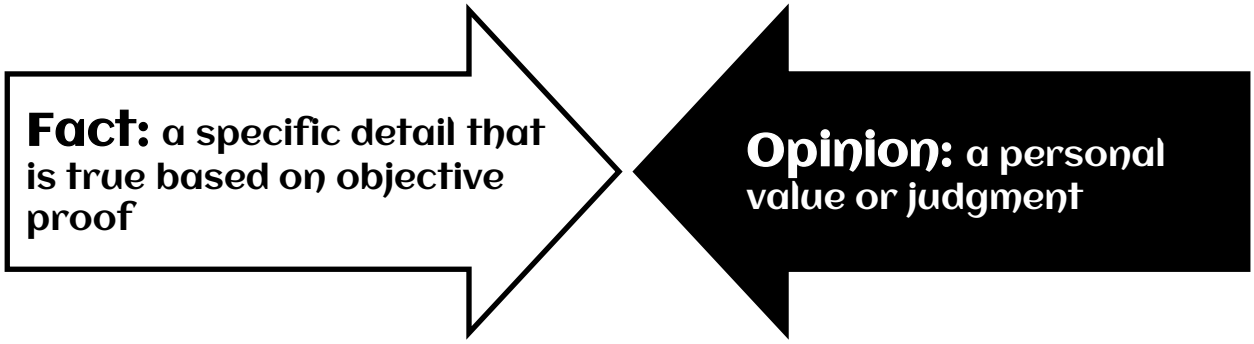
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Determining Purpose, Viewpoint, and Bias

Use of Facts vs. Opinion

The author's viewpoint is often revealed through their use or omission of certain facts, and how the balance between use of facts and opinions.



FACT	OPINION
➢Is objective	➢Is subjective
➢Is discovered	➢Is created
➢States Reality	➢Interprets Reality
➢Can be verified	➢Cannot be verified
➢Presented without biased words	➢Presented with biased words
Example: An orange is citrus.	Example: An orange tastes great

WORDS THAT INDICATE BIAS/OPINION (Adj./Adv. That express value/judgment/interpretation)

Awful	**Best**	**Favorite**	**Great**	**More**	**Terrible**
Amazing	**Better**	**Frightful**	**Handsome**	**Most**	**Unbelievable**
Bad	**Disgusting**	**Fun**	**Horrible**	**Smart**	**Ugly**
Beautiful	**Exciting**	**Good**	**Miserable**	**Stupid**	**very**

WORDS THAT QUALIFY POSITIONS OR BELIEFS

All	**Could**	**Likely**	**Never**	**Possibly**	**Should**
Always	**Every**	**May**	**Often**	**Possible**	**Sometimes**
Appear	**Has/have to**	**Might**	**Only**	**Probably**	**Think**
Believe	**It is believed**	**Must**	**Ought to**	**Seem**	**usually**

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Facts vs. Opinions Exercise

Use you notes to determine the facts and opinions in the following passages. Underline the facts, circle any words that indicate bias/opinion, and place brackets around the author's opinions.

Twilight is a series of four vampire-themed fantasy romance novels by American author Stephenie Meyer. It charts a period in the life of Isabella "Bella" Swan, a teenage girl who moves to Forks, Washington, and falls in love with a 104-year-old vampire named Edward Cullen. Although it has been wildly popular, it could be one of the most poorly written examples of young adult literature. The series has sold millions of copies and grossed incredible returns in the box office as a movie adaptation, despite it's shallow character development and scattered plot-line.

What do the opinion statements reveal about the author's viewpoint? _____

_____

NFL Football is wildly entertaining and quite possibly the best way to spend a quiet Sunday afternoon. Up until the 1960s, the NFL was the dominant professional football league and faced little competition. Recently the sport has come under attack because of concerns over violence and long-term injury. Injuries can happen in any sport, and those who desire to limit the contact in the sport are ridiculous to even suggest changing America's greatest sporting competition. The NFL is and always will be an amazing spectacle of athleticism and intense competition.

What do the opinion statements reveal about the author's viewpoint? _____

_____

Lotteries and gambling are horrible ways to generate revenue for government funds or for even a local fundraiser. All state lotteries and gambling institutions should reconsider their practices and possibly be made illegal as forms of revenue. Lotteries, like any form of gambling, are susceptible to fraud, despite the high degree of scrutiny claimed by the organizers. Numerous lottery scams exist, and are used to generate funds for corrupt or even illegal activities. Some advance fee fraud scams on the Internet are based on lotteries. The fraud starts with spam congratulating the recipient on their recent lottery win. The email explains that in order to release funds the email recipient must part with a certain amount (as tax/fees) as per the rules or risk forfeiture.

What do the opinion statements reveal about the author's viewpoint? _____

_____